

For the Friends with Benefits project, I collaborated with classmates to create a board game with a technical implementation for our client in the style of our company, LOOP.

Trends

I first aimed to conduct competitive research to find inspiration for a fun board game. Since this proved challenging due to the many great games available and varying personal preferences, I decided to take a step back and focus on board game trends instead, specifically for the year 2024:

- * **App integration:** many gamers want to combine traditional board games with modern technology to create a richer, layered gaming experience.
- * **Sustainable materials:** more games are being made from recycled and eco-friendly materials.
- * **Games with a message or educational themes:** beyond entertainment, games that spark discussion and raise awareness about societal challenges are gaining popularity.
- * **Immersive storytelling:** players want engaging narratives where their decisions influence the outcome and story progression.
- * **Fast-paced games:** alongside complex games, there is a trend towards easy-to-learn, quick games, ideal for casual play or as warm-ups for longer sessions.
- * **Cooperative gameplay:** many games now emphasize working together toward a shared goal instead of competing.

[Source by **Galaxus** & **De Spellentoren**]

We wanted to use as many elements as described above, but focused more on trends like app integration and fast-paced gameplay, since we were making a party game. The goal wasn't competition, but rather making people laugh and get to know each other. Other trends fit better with different game types, while ours needed to be fun and accessible for larger groups.

Interview

To do further research on how to improve our party game with our target group, which consisted of younger people aged 18+, I decided to do an interview and spoke with a 23-year-old who was interested in party games. Along with my classmates, I prepared a set of questions and conducted individual interviews. Afterward, we combined our findings and identified key points we could use to improve our collective board game.

- * Young people love party games because they help people open up and make new connections.
- * Deep, personal questions can be intimidating but are good for breaking the ice and getting to know others better.
- * Funny and lighthearted questions create memorable moments through laughs and banter.
- * Different categories make the game more dynamic and exciting, catering to varied tastes and adding unpredictability.
- * Creating your own rules is fun, but clear guidelines on what is allowed are essential to avoid confusion.
- * Board games don't always have to be competitive to be enjoyable.
- * Many young people have short attention spans, so fast-paced rounds or games work better.

Card Design

Based on the group stylescape, which featured darker and "spicy" colors like black and deep red, I designed the cards for our conceptual board game, Friends with Benefits. This game is daring and fun, so I wanted the design to reflect that: bold, playful, not childish or old-fashioned and still fitting the stylescape's mood. Since most board game elements were dark, I made the cards more vibrant to help them stand out and to clarify the game's three categories:

1. Casual: green cards, representing the mildest spice level. I added a simple shirt icon to emphasize the casual and easygoing nature.
2. Mild: orange cards, indicating a medium spice level. The icon is a slightly sweating emoji, symbolizing the "warming up" or moderate spice phase.
3. Spicy: red cards, representing the spiciest category. The icon is a chili pepper, highlighting the boldest, most daring challenges.

This color coding and icon system helps players quickly recognize the category and spice level, making the game easier and more fun to play.



Questions

I also created questions for two of the three stages of the board game. I focused on the "casual" and "mild" stages, making sure the questions remained lighthearted and didn't delve too deeply into personal or spicy topics. These questions are designed to help break the ice while keeping the mood fun and easygoing.

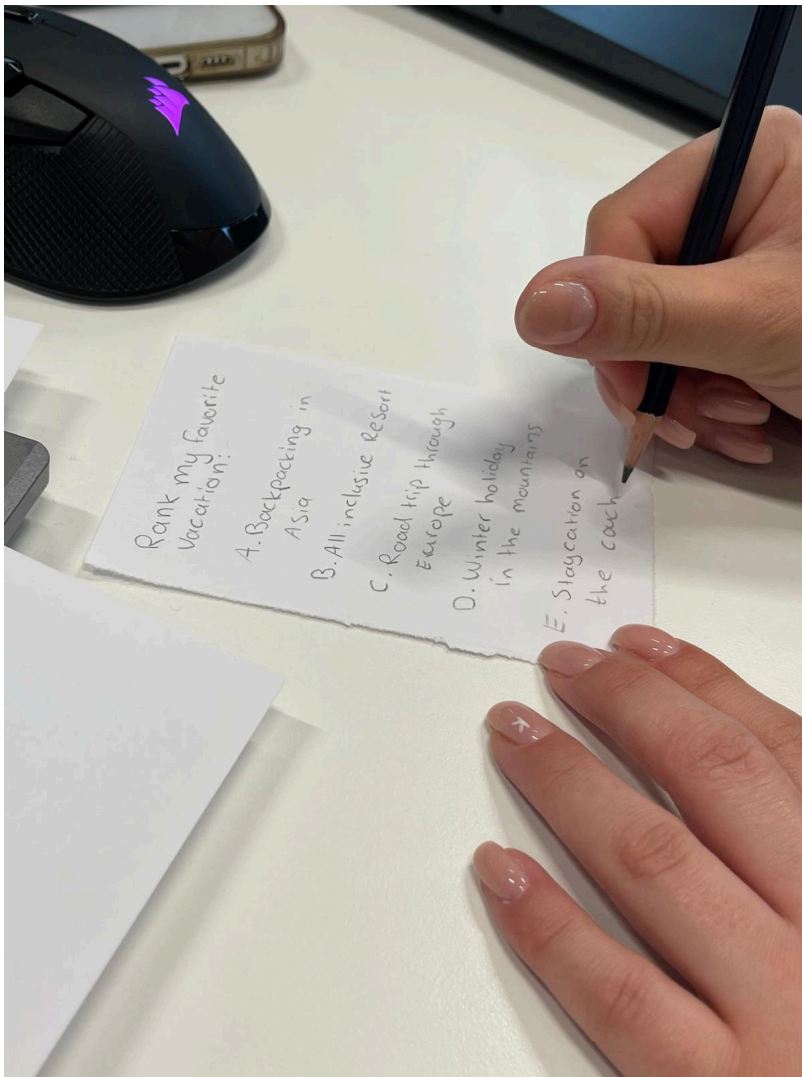
Poster

In the end, my card design was also incorporated into the poster for our game.



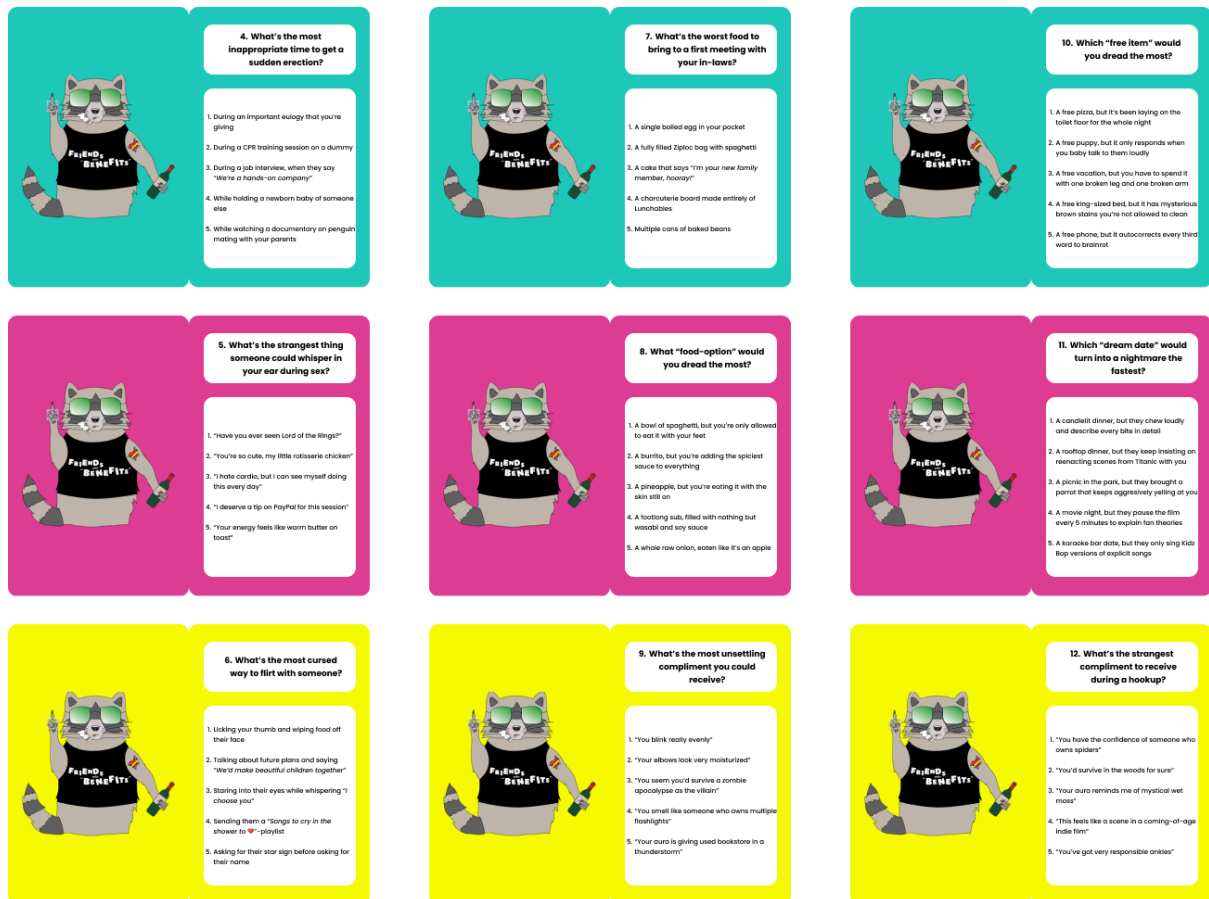
Paper Prototype

We made a paper prototype to quickly test the game with students aged 18+. They found it fun and easy to understand, including the different question types. The rounds were fast-paced (about 1 minute), which was our goal. We also saw that a timer could help with pacing. The spicier questions made students more nervous but also created a more exciting and fun atmosphere with more laughter.



[FEEDBACK 1 HIGHLIGHTS]

After feedback from the teacher and user-testing with people 18+, we made our style more colorful, focused on spicier subjects and icons and created a mascot, Rick. This was well received during testing. Because of the style change, I updated my card design to be colorful and include Rick on the back of every card, making the game stand out.



Website

I created the about page for our website so players could learn more about us and to make the game stand out. Since the game is spicy and funny, I added a section about the game and another about Rick, our mascot. To emphasize the fun tone, I wrote a playful rhyming verse describing Rick. I used our colorful, spicy and attention-grabbing style throughout the page.

WE SEE YOU... 00

(WEIRDO)

ABOUT RICK, I GUESS.

Rick. Rick. Rick.

Rick is sick. And thick. And most of the time a dick.
And loves a kick. And a good trick. And is searching
for a wonderful click. Rick is single. Rick has no
chick. Oh - and Rick is our mascot.

We came up with our mascot Rick, the perfect
model for our card game: fun, daring, appealing,
but very trashy as well. Loves to drink, smoke and
enjoy life to the fullest. But also happy to help and
navigate you guys through our game.



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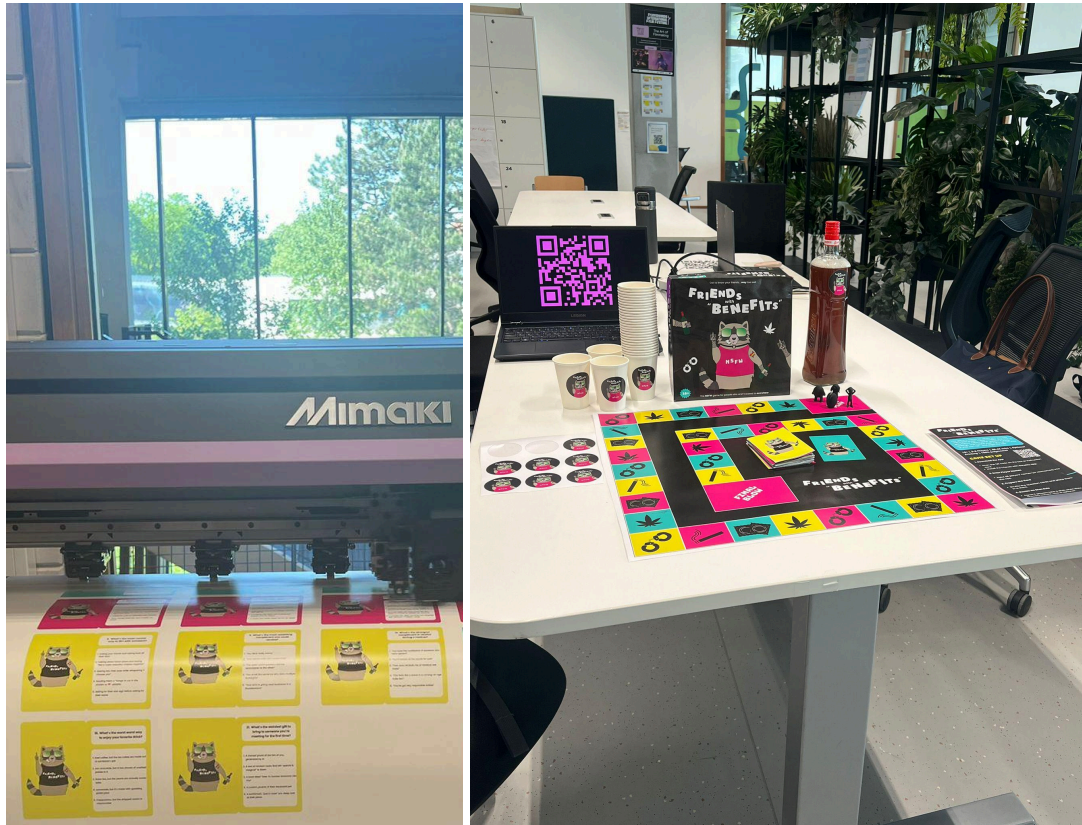


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Showcase Event

At the Showcase Event, I printed and glued the front and back of all the cards so guests could play with them. This was important for the app, which needs the card numbers to work. We also decorated our stand with shots, snacks and Rick stickers to promote the game.



[FEEDBACK 2 HIGHLIGHTS]

Guests were very impressed and enthusiastic about our stand and game. They found the theme thrilling, fun and creative, and the mascot stood out. The game was enjoyable, with funny questions and a fitting shot-taking concept. Alternatives to drinking, like awkward tasks, were appreciated.

Areas to improve for in the future:

- * The board could be more interactive with boosts or power-ups.
- * The app has bugs: if a phone disconnects, the lobby crashes.
- * The ranking system is unclear: icons could help show ranking direction.
- * Some questions require too much reading: shortening them or reducing questions per round could speed up gameplay.